Gmail

Moon Duchin <mduchin@gmail.com>

questions about ACS

James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov> Thu, Jul 25, 2024 at 7:21 AM
To: Moon Duchin <mduchin@mggg.org>

Census - General

Good morning Moon -
I have found a colleague who is looking into your question, and I will hopefully be able to connect you two in the very near future. On a side note, we have heard the need for the "alone or in combination" values for the CVAP file from other data users and have made a note of the desire for that information. We will add it to any redesign conversations that occur around the CVAP special tabulation.
I will be in touch as soon as I hear back from my colleague.
Regards,
James

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Census - General

From: Moon Duchin <mduchin@mggg.org>
Sent: Wednesday, July 24, 2024 12:22 PM
To: James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov>
Subject: Re: questions about ACS

Hi James, OK, thank you for that! I was able to get in touch with the RDH people and it turns out that they were in fact creating "alone or in combination" metacategories without having that be super clear in the column names -- so this mystery is resolved.

Here is a summary of the broader question I'd like to ask some appropriate ACS expert: I'm trying to build a best-practices dataset with disaggregated CVAP on blocks, for redistricting purposes. (Many people already do this, but with methodology I think is not great, and my collaborators and I are trying to use a proper Bayesian framework to do it well.) Ultimately it is necessary to create a CVAP estimate for the kinds of categories that appear in litigation, but these are not possible to construct exactly using any special tabs that I am aware of. For instance, "any-part-Black" should include people who are Black and Hispanic.

We have brainstormed a few ways of handling this, but we would like to discuss it with someone who has a view in to the details of data construction.

Thanks very much!
Best,
Moon

On Tue, Jul 23, 2024 at 3:05 PM James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov> wrote:

Census - General

Thank you -
That resolved my concern, and I am now looking at the same vintage. After looking at these two block groups, I can say that the first one does appear to be a rounding issue.

The total population for BG 080010150003 is 155 which is the same value as when adding the Hispanic and non-Hispanic population counts together. When looking at the non-Hispanic races added together, they come to 80. It is reasonable to believe that a combination of rounding down for the two race categories and rounding up for the non-Hispanic value could have resulted in the 5-person discrepancy.

The second block group, I am still getting different values when I open the CVAP file. As you mention, this may be a RDH processing issue. When I add the non-Hispanic values, I get a perfect match of the non-Hispanic Race total to the non-Hispanic component race categories sum total.

You mentioned you also had some additional more technical issues you wished to discuss with one of our ACS team. Can you provide some information as to what those questions pertain to so I can direct you to the right person?
Please also let me know if you have any additional questions for me.
Thank you
James

geoname	Intitle	geoid	lnnumber	cit_est	cit_moe	cvap_est	cvap_moe	STATE	BG
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Total	1500000US080050870001	1	1215	449	1110	417	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Not Hispanic or Latino	1500000US080050870001	2	1090	447	990	414	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native Alone	1500000US080050870001	3	15	27	15	27	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Asian Alone	1500000US080050870001	4	15	27	15	27	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Black or African American Alone	1500000US080050870001	5	250	189	195	157	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander Alone	1500000US080050870001	6	0	13	0	13	08	080050870001

Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	White Alone	1500000US080050870001	7	440	172	410	152	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native and White	1500000US080050870001	8	50	74	50	74	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Asian and White	1500000US080050870001	9	0	13	0	13	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Black or African American and White	1500000US080050870001	10	95	108	80	99	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native and Black or African American	1500000US080050870001	11	225	319	225	319	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Remainder of Two or More Race Responses	1500000US080050870001	12	0	13	0	13	08	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Hispanic or Latino	1500000US080050870001	13	125	95	120	95	08	080050870001

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Census - General

From: Moon Duchin <mduchin@mggg.org>
Sent: Tuesday, July 23, 2024 2:07 PM
To: James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov>
Subject: Re: questions about ACS

Hi James, thanks for getting back to me!

No, it's the 5-year ending in 2021. The collaborator of mine who found this example pulled the data from Redistricting Data Hub: https://redistrictingdatahub.org/dataset/colorado-block-group-cvap-data-2021/

If the error was caused by RDH, I apologize! I've let my collaborator know she should just use the census API in the future and not rely on an unnecessary middleman.

Moon

On Tue, Jul 23, 2024 at 1:48 PM James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov> wrote:

Census - General

Hello Moon -
I made it back to the office and am looking into this for you. The first thing I did was pull up the most current data from our CVAP custom tabulation for the two block groups you are examining. I am getting different numbers than what you are listing. Can you confirm a few things before I push forward?

1) Are you using the special CVAP tabulation from this webpage? Citizen Voting Age Population by Race and Ethnicity (census.gov)
    a. If yes, are you using the most current version of the data (2018-2022 5-year ACS)
    b. If no, what source and vintage of data are you using?

Thank you,
James

geoname	Intitle	geoid	lnnumber	cit_est	cit_moe	cvap_est	cvap_moe	BG
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	Total	1500000US080010150003	1	175	82	175	82	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	Not Hispanic or Latino	1500000US080010150003	2	80	72	80	72	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native Alone	1500000US080010150003	3	0	13	0	13	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	Asian Alone	1500000US080010150003	4	4	11	4	11	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams	Black or African American Alone	1500000US080010150003	5	0	13	0	13	080010150003

County, Colorado								
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander Alone	1500000US080010150003	6	0	13	0	13	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	White Alone	1500000US080010150003	7	70	68	70	68	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native and White	1500000US080010150003	8	0	13	0	13	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	Asian and White	1500000US080010150003	9	0	13	0	13	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	Black or African American and White	1500000US080010150003	10	0	13	0	13	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native and Black or African American	1500000US080010150003	11	0	13	0	13	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	Remainder of Two or More Race Responses	1500000US080010150003	12	0	13	0	13	080010150003
Block Group 3, Census Tract 150, Adams County, Colorado	Hispanic or Latino	1500000US080010150003	13	100	48	100	48	080010150003
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Total	1500000US080050870001	1	1255	295	865	208	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Not Hispanic or Latino	1500000US080050870001	2	960	249	715	187	080050870001

Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native Alone	1500000US080050870001	3	0	13	0	13	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Asian Alone	1500000US080050870001	4	15	27	15	27	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Black or African American Alone	1500000US080050870001	5	390	251	245	152	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander Alone	1500000US080050870001	6	0	13	0	13	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	White Alone	1500000US080050870001	7	405	200	340	141	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native and White	1500000US080050870001	8	0	13	0	13	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Asian and White	1500000US080050870001	9	0	13	0	13	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Black or African American and White	1500000US080050870001	10	95	109	75	86	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	American Indian or Alaska Native and Black or African American	1500000US080050870001	11	60	117	40	83	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870, Arapahoe County, Colorado	Remainder of Two or More Race Responses	1500000US080050870001	12	0	13	0	13	080050870001
Block Group 1, Census Tract 870,	Hispanic or Latino	1500000US080050870001	13	290	212	155	116	080050870001

Arapahoe County, Colorado								

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Census - General

From: Moon Duchin <mduchin@mggg.org>
Sent: Wednesday, July 17, 2024 10:28 AM
To: James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov>
Subject: Re: questions about ACS

Awesome, thanks so much for looking into this, James! Not urgent, so please do consult the guru.

(Also, I do have some nitty gritty follow-up questions, so if you wouldn't mind putting me in touch with this person, I would appreciate that!)

On Wed, Jul 17, 2024 at 9:36 AM James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov> wrote:

> Census - General
>
> I think this is going to require a little research on my end. Rounding is applied to the CVAP tab but with those values, it doesn't seem the likely cause. Plus, the other 40% discrepancy seems to be something else. I need to talk to our custom tab guru next week when I get back. Is this urgent or do I have time? If you are in a time crunch, I can check to see if one of my ACS colleagues can jump in here in my place.
>
> Rounding rule:
> The rounding schematic for all tables is: • 0 remains 0 • 1-7 rounds to 4 • 8 or greater rounds to the nearest multiple of 5 (i.e., 864 rounds to 865, 982 rounds to 980)
>
> **********
> **James Whitehorne, Chief**
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>
> Census - General
>
> ---
>
> **From:** Moon Duchin <mduchin@mggg.org>
> **Sent:** Tuesday, July 16, 2024 11:43 PM
> **To:** James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov>
> **Subject:** Re: questions about ACS
>
> Hmm that helps but doesn't clear up the whole mystery...
>
> in the first block group example, the total number of people with a race ID is 80 while the non-Hisp number is 85. I suppose this can be because of rounding?
>
> in the second block group example, I still don't understand why races can add up to 40% more than the non-Hisp total. After all, `CVAP_AIA21` is AMIN **alone**, `CVAP_ASN21` is Asian **alone**, `CVAP_BLK21` is Black **alone**, `CVAP_AIW21` is AMIN and White, etc -- it sounds like the categories are constructed not to overlap, so people won't be double-counted.
>
> Best,
> Moon
>
> On Tue, Jul 16, 2024 at 8:58 PM James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov> wrote:
>
> > Let me know if this addresses the issues you are seeing.

1) The ACS currently uses the two question format for race and ethnicity. The ethnicity question comes first asking if someone is or is not Hispanic. The race question is next asking respondents to pick one or more races. This race question includes a category for Some Other Race (SOR). So to answer one of your questions, yes someone in the ACS can select more than one race.
2) The race categories reported in the CVAP product are all non-Hispanic race. If someone is Hispanic then they are reported as Hispanic. Then, the remaining Non-Hispanic population is divided into their race component categories. This is based on how DOJ does their analysis.

Hope that helps. Let me know if things still looks problematic.

Regards
James

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From: Moon Duchin <mduchin@mggg.org>
Sent: Tuesday, July 16, 2024 4:32:05 PM
To: James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov>
Subject: Re: questions about ACS

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Awesome! Thanks so much for the speedy response!

I can preview one of my questions for you here.

First question: I'm confused about whether people can identify with multiple races or no race on the ACS. Here are two examples of 2020 block groups in Colorado.

GEOID20	080010150003
CVAP_TOT21	155
CVAP_NHS21	85
CVAP_AIA21	0
CVAP_ASN21	10
CVAP_BLK21	0
CVAP_NHP21	0
CVAP_WHT21	70
CVAP_AIW21	0
CVAP_ASW21	0
CVAP_BLW21	0
CVAP_AIB21	0
CVAP_2OM21	0
CVAP_HSP21	70

GEOID20	080050870001
CVAP_TOT21	1110
CVAP_NHS21	990
CVAP_AIA21	290
CVAP_ASN21	15
CVAP_BLK21	500
CVAP_NHP21	0
CVAP_WHT21	410
CVAP_AIW21	50
CVAP_ASW21	0
CVAP_BLW21	80
CVAP_AIB21	225
CVAP_2OM21	0
CVAP_HSP21	120

In the first one, it seems that most Hispanic respondents listed NO race.

In the second, it seems that many respondents listed SEVERAL races.

I didn't think either of those was possible in the structure of ACS data!

Do you know the deal with this?

And then, I have a follow-up question about best practices for working with this data....

Let me know if a phone call seems better!
Moon

On Tue, Jul 16, 2024 at 6:57 PM James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov> wrote:

Hello Moon -
Nice to hear from you. That specific tab(CVAP) is one that is managed by my office and which was originally requested by DOJ after the 2010 Census. The groupings contained in that tab are an adaptation of the Office of Management and Budget's Bulletin 00-02 which was issued as guidance on how to aggregate race and ethnicity data for civil and voting rights under the 1997 race and ethnicity standards. The "adaptation" is the inclusion of the Hispanic category. That guidance was rescinded under the new SPD15 standards issued earlier this year but it will take time to adapt to the new standards and guidance. You should be able to find the old Bulletin 00-02 with a quick google search.
I am in CA at a conference this week and am back in the office on Tuesday next week. Happy to jump on the phone next week or to field questions by email any time. I can probably swing a call this week too, just would take more coordination with the conference sessions and time zone difference.
Just let me know what works.
Best Regards,
James

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From: Moon Duchin <mduchin@mggg.org>
Sent: Tuesday, July 16, 2024 3:41:00 PM
To: James Whitehorne (CENSUS/ADDC FED) <James.Whitehorne@census.gov>
Subject: questions about ACS

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Dear James, hello!

I have some questions about how race data breaks down in the ACS -- I'm very confused about it! I found this information sheet that says to reach out to the Redistricting Data Office, and I guess that means your team :)

Any way I can catch you (or someone else that you suggest) and ask you some questions about how race categories are handled in the block group special tabs?

Thanks and best,
Moon

--
Moon Duchin
Director, MGGG Redistricting Lab
Tisch College of Civic Life
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